DRINKS BY NEAT

The Bartender's *AI Prompt Book*

Eight real bar jobs, worked step by step with AI. Plus a stack of ready-to-use prompts. Works with ChatGPT, Claude, and Gemini. Written by a bartender, not a tech bro.

GUIDED BUILDS
8 jobs done with the AI in 5 steps — not one-shot prompts

YOUR BAR, LOADED
One page about your bar that makes every answer fit your bar

THE RIGHT TOOL
Which AI to use for which job — and which to skip

QUICK REFERENCE
Copy-paste prompts for everything else



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FREE EDITION

Bartender AI Manifesto

Impact on creativity

Humanity is profoundly lazy - it's actually one of our strengths, and has given us many, many things. However, any human given an easy answer to something rarely decides to continue learning in the area, resulting in a lot of surface-level skill. This damages your immediate creativity, as any answer from AI is generally not all that creative, but will also prevent you from steadily gathering the peripheral skills to either be authentically creative, or apply uncreative things but in creative ways, such as from one industry to another. This is a skill that AI usage discourages. Finally, as more people resort to AI, more of the creative space is cannibalised and fed through the machine, and if entire groups of individuals no longer possess creative skills, then the ability to bounce off each other reduces and the impact is even greater. All while AI is just there as an easily-justifiable alternative. Note, this isn't AI's problem or something we can really expect legislation or corporate responsibility to help with - it is a decision purely for the individual - in the same way that each of us has to practice willpower in how we approach our diet.

Vulnerability in reliance

Using AI to learn has drawbacks, but also so many benefits. However, using AI to execute something, particularly as you build upon it, leaves you reliant on AI to maintain and grow. There are creative and moral issues to this if AI remains free/affordable, but much greater economic dangers if it doesn't. And it absolutely 1000% won't. AI companies are unapologetically following the exact same predatory model as most tech companies - the uber model - go in, undercut competition/alternatives until their userbase declines to the point of collapse, then crank prices when you have reliance. The only thing that challenges this post-collapse are operators getting the necessary capital together to counter-act, which, in the context of AI, given the companies involved, can only be done by corporations (or countries), for whom there can never be the expectation of another approach. Again, this is a responsible usage issue - using AI vs. becoming so reliant on it as to be vulnerable, for both the individual and the company.

Impact on designers, creatives, etc

This isn't to argue that removing work from designers is inherently unethical - there are obvious capitalist rebuttals to that. It is, however, purely to highlight the tragedy of the commons - that if all of us are in denial of the impact on creatives, then they will be destroyed very quickly - and we should ask if we want to live in that world, or should change our behaviours. Basically, people shouldn't be in denial of the costs to others of AI usage. More broadly, the corporations pushing AI forward are very clearly ruthless, have extensive governmental capture, and we strengthen them with every usage of AI - we shouldn't deny that.

This is not a prompt list. *It's a method.*

Anyone can paste one prompt and get an average answer. The skill is in what you say next. So the heart of this book is eight **guided builds**: real bar jobs, done with the AI in numbered steps. You send a message, the AI answers, and the book tells you exactly what to say back.

NEVER USED AI BEFORE? DO THIS ONCE.

1. Open **ChatGPT, Claude, or Gemini** — app or website. The free version is fine.
2. Start a **new chat**. A chat is one conversation. The AI remembers everything inside it.
3. Copy a prompt from this book. A prompt is just the message you send.
4. Replace everything in **[brackets]** with your own details. More detail = better answer.
5. Send it. Read the answer. Then reply — ask for changes, like you would with a coworker.
6. During a build, **stay in the same chat** for every step. Don't open a new one halfway.

THE JOB	The situation, in one line. Find the card that matches yours.
TOOL PICK	Which AI to use for this job, and why.
LOAD YOUR BAR	What to paste in before you start. Usually your Bar Context File (page 5).
THE BUILD	3–5 numbered steps. Each step: what to send, and why it works.
THE BAR	A checklist. If you can't tick every line, you're not done.

01 **Create a menu cocktail**
From idea to a drink you can serve

02 **Cost it & price it**
Know what it costs and what to charge

03 **Batch it for volume**
Scale a recipe without ruining it

04 **Fix a drink that's off**
Find the problem, fix it, keep the fix

05 **Master new kit or technique**
From the box to a routine your team runs

06 **Make it look like it tastes**
Photos and a week of posts from one drink

07 **Allergen-proof the menu**
Answers your floor team can trust

08 **Teach the team the new menu**
Specs into heads before doors open

After the cards: a **quick reference** — more prompts, ready to copy. Use them the same way: send, read, push back.

The tools we suggest

You don't need all of these. Start with one free chat AI and NotebookLM. If you pay for one thing, make it your chat AI. Everything else is optional until you need it.

TOOL	FREE PLAN	PAID	BEST FOR
ChatGPT CHAT AI	Yes — daily limits on the smartest model and on image making.	~$20/mo — longer chats, smarter answers, more images, better voice mode.	Your main workbench. Every build in this book. Voice mode while you prep.
Claude CHAT AI	Yes — daily message limit.	~$20/mo — much higher limits, plus Projects (save your Bar Context File once, it's always loaded).	Longer documents: training guides, house SOPs, menus. Careful, natural writing.
Gemini CHAT AI	Yes — generous, and image making is included free.	~$20/mo — smarter model, more image and video features.	If you live in Google's world (Gmail, Docs). Making images inside the same chat.
Perplexity RESEARCH	Yes — a few advanced searches per day. Enough to start.	~$20/mo — unlimited advanced searches.	Research with sources you can check: trends, products, local rules, how pros do a technique.
NotebookLM YOUR DOCUMENTS	Yes — free, and the free plan is enough.	Exists, but you won't need it.	The team's study tool. Upload your menu and training docs; it answers only from them, and can make an audio briefing.
Midjourney IMAGES	No free plan.	From ~$10/mo.	The best-looking drink and poster imagery. Worth it if visuals matter to your bar.
Adobe Firefly IMAGES	Yes — a small number of free credits per month.	From ~$10/mo.	Print work. Trained only on licensed images, so it's the safe choice for menus and posters you sell with.
Kling · Runway · Veo VIDEO	Trial credits, enough to test.	Roughly $10–30/mo.	Short mood clips and backgrounds only. The real build is always your phone filming your hands.

Prices are ballpark, checked August 2026 — they change, so check before you subscribe. The next two pages explain which tool does which *job*, so you can judge any new tool that launches after this book.

Five things every good prompt has

Every prompt in this book has these five parts. Once you know them, you can write your own.

1

ROLE

Tell the AI who to be. "You are a beverage director with 15 years in cocktail bars." It answers better in character.

2

CONTEXT

Tell it about your bar. The AI can't see your shelf. If you don't say what you stock, it guesses.

3

TASK

Ask for one thing per message. Ask for three things and all three come back worse.

4

FORMAT

Say what the answer should look like: "a table," "a spec in oz and ml," "one sentence."

5

LIMITS

Say your rules: budget, prep time, what your team can do, what you won't serve.

★

THE [BRACKETS]

Everything in [brackets] is yours to fill in. "Overproof Jamaican rum, heavy funk" beats "rum," every time.

The second message matters more than the first. The first answer is always a draft. Say what's wrong with it: "shorter," "less sweet," "that garnish won't survive a busy night." The AI remembers the whole chat and adjusts. This is the entire trick, and most people never do it.

Make it show its work. For numbers, ask for the math line by line. For facts, ask "what are you unsure about?" The AI sounds confident even when it's wrong. Treat it like a bright new hire: useful, fast, needs checking.

You are still the bartender. The AI drafts; you decide. Taste everything. Check costs against your invoices. Check allergens against real labels. Always.

The Bar Context File — *10 minutes, once*

One page about your bar. Paste it at the start of every chat, and every answer comes back fitted to your bar — your bottles, your prices, your team. This is the most useful page in the book.

How to make it

1. Open your phone's notes app.
2. Copy the four headings from the box below.
3. Fill them in. Ten minutes.
4. Paste the whole note at the top of every new AI chat, before your first question.
5. When the menu changes, update the note. Two minutes.

Or save it once, so it's always loaded

1. **ChatGPT:** Settings → Personalization → Custom Instructions → paste it there.
2. **Claude:** make a Project → paste it into the Project's knowledge.
3. **Gemini:** Settings → Saved Info → paste it there.

Do one of these and you can skip step 4 forever — the AI already knows your bar in every chat.

1 · THE BOTTLES & THE ROOM

Your well spirits · 5 backbar bottles you love · house syrups & preps · glassware · ice setup · type of venue · covers on a busy night

2 · THE NUMBERS

Cocktail price range · target pour cost % (what a drink costs you ÷ its menu price) · prep hours per week

3 · THE TEAM

How many people · skill level · the hardest technique you can run on a Saturday

4 · THE VOICE

Copy in two menu descriptions you like — yours or anyone's. The AI will write in that style.

Pick tools by *job*, not by hype

Tool names change every few months. The jobs don't. Learn the six jobs and you can place any new tool in seconds.

JOB 01
Thinking & writing partner

ChatGPT, Claude, or Gemini. Your main workbench: recipes, costing, menu copy, training material — every build in this book. All three are good. Pick one and learn it. What matters: it can **save your Bar Context File** (page 5), it has **voice mode** (talk to it while you prep), and it takes **photos and files** (shoot an invoice instead of typing it). Free versions work. Paying (~$20/month) gets you longer chats, smarter answers, and image making in the same app.

Used in: builds 01–05, 07, 08, and most of the quick reference

JOB 02
Research with sources

Perplexity, or the "search the web" switch in your chat AI. Use it when the answer must be current and provable: trends, what a distillery actually does, local rules, equipment reviews. Simple test: if being wrong would embarrass you in front of a rep or an inspector, use a tool that shows its sources — and click one to check.

Used in: build 05 · trend scans, spirit deep-dives, anything legal

JOB 03
Making images

Midjourney (best-looking results, ~$10/month, small learning curve). **ChatGPT's or Gemini's built-in images** (easiest — just ask in the same chat, and Gemini's are free). **Adobe Firefly** (trained only on licensed images — the safe choice for printed menus and posters). Use them for concepts, mood boards, and artwork. One rule: never show an AI image as a photo of the drink you actually serve.

Used in: build 06, and the poster-art prompt

JOB 04
Making video

Kling, Runway, or Veo. Honest advice: AI video is good for mood clips and backgrounds, not for showing the drink being made. What actually works for bar content: film your own hands on your phone, and let your chat AI write the shot list, the opening line, and the caption. Cheaper, faster, and guests trust it more.

Used in: build 06, step 5

JOB 05

Eyes & ears — the hidden modes

These live inside the chat app you already have. **Photo input:** photograph your backbar and ask for a count sheet. Photograph a competitor's menu and ask what it tells you. Photograph a failed batch and ask what went wrong. **Voice mode:** drill specs or talk through a costing while your hands are busy. **NotebookLM** (free, by Google): upload your menu and training docs — it answers questions using only your documents, and can even turn them into an audio briefing your team can listen to on the train.

Used in: builds 05, 07, 08

JOB 06

Numbers you'll act on

Chat AIs are good at **setting up** math and bad at **guaranteeing** it. For anything involving money: ask for every calculation line by line, check one line yourself with a calculator, and keep the final numbers in a spreadsheet. Ask the AI for tables you can paste into Sheets or Excel. The AI is the calculator; the spreadsheet is the record.

Used in: builds 02 and 03, and all the admin prompts

RULE 0

Straight talk

Start free. If you pay for one thing, make it your main chat AI — it covers five of the six jobs. **Privacy:** assume free tools may learn from what you paste. Recipes and menus: fine. Sales data, staff matters: keep them out, or use a paid business account. **Honesty:** label AI images when guests might think they're real. Trust is the product.

PART ONE

The Guided Builds

Eight jobs, done in steps. Send step 1, read the answer, send step 2. Stay in the same chat the whole way. The checklist at the end tells you when you're done.

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01 CREATE · 02 COST · 03 BATCH · 04 FIX · 05 MASTER · 06 SHOW · 07 PROTECT · 08 TEACH



01 Create a menu cocktail

THE JOB You need one new drink for the list — from an idea, a season, or a product you want to feature.

TOOL PICK

ChatGPT or Claude. This is a long conversation, so use your main chat AI. Use voice mode if you think better out loud. Don't use a search tool — you're creating, not researching.

LOAD YOUR BAR

Start a new chat. Paste your **Bar Context File** (page 5). Then add: what the drink is for (season, menu slot, product to feature) and **one drink on your list that sells well** — it teaches the AI what your guests like.

1 Ask for ideas only — no recipes yet

> You are an award-winning cocktail developer. Give me 8 ideas for **[WHAT YOU NEED — "a spring drink featuring our house amaro"]**. One line per idea. No recipes yet. Make them different from each other, and include two wild ones.

WHY — asking for ideas before recipes stops you settling for the first thing it says. The "two wild ones" tells it it's allowed to surprise you.

2 Pick one, choose the drink's shape

> I pick idea **[NUMBER]**. Show me 3 ways to build it — for example as a sour, a stirred drink, or a highball. For each: one line on how it would taste, and which one my team could make fastest on a busy night.

WHY — you choose the drink's structure on purpose, instead of taking whatever the AI defaulted to.

3 Get the full recipe — and make it explain itself

> Write the full spec in oz and ml: every ingredient with amounts, method, glass, ice, garnish. Then justify each ingredient in one line. If you can't justify one, remove it. Finish by telling me which ingredient a guest is most likely to ask about.

WHY — the "justify each ingredient" line kills filler. Continued on the next page →

4 Make it attack its own drink

> Now switch roles: you are my bar manager. Look at this drink on a packed Saturday at my target pour cost. What breaks — prep load, build speed, garnish, ticket times? Rewrite the spec to fix the two biggest problems without losing the idea.

WHY — the AI is very good at criticizing its own work, but only if you tell it to switch sides. This step is where amateurs stop and pros start.

5 Make the drink for real, then come back

> I made it. Result: **[WHAT YOU TASTED — "smells great, middle tastes hollow, finish too short"]**. Fix that, but don't lose **[WHAT'S WORKING]**. Give me the new spec and one line on what each change does.

WHY — the loop between the glass and the chat is the real work. Two or three rounds is normal. Stay in the same chat.

THE BAR — BEFORE IT GOES ON THE MENU

— **You tasted it at least twice** — once made at full speed, with service ice and glassware.

— **You costed it from your invoices** (Build 02), not from the AI's guesses.

— **Your slowest bartender can build it in 90 seconds** mid-rush.

— **The garnish still looks right** after sitting 10 minutes.

— The story fits in one sentence a busy server will actually say.

02 Cost it & price it

THE JOB Find out what a drink really costs you per serve, and what to charge for it.

TOOL PICK

Your main chat AI. If it takes photos, photograph the invoice instead of typing prices. Keep the final numbers in a spreadsheet — the AI does the math, the spreadsheet keeps the record.

LOAD YOUR BAR

You need: the recipe, real bottle prices **from your latest invoice** (not from memory), your target pour cost % (drink cost ÷ menu price), and the cost of any house syrups. Don't know a prep cost? The AI helps you work it out first.

1 Lay out the numbers

> You are a beverage cost controller. Cost this cocktail. Recipe: **[FULL SPEC]**. Bottle prices: **[INGREDIENT — BOTTLE SIZE — PRICE, one per line]**. House preps: **[PREP — BATCH COST — BATCH SIZE]**. Make a table: ingredient, pour size, cost per oz, cost per pour. Show every line of math.

WHY — "show every line" is the rule. One mixed-up bottle size (750ml vs 1L) makes every number after it wrong.

2 Check it before you trust it

> Redo the cost-per-oz column from scratch and tell me if anything changed. Then list the three numbers in this table you're least sure about.

WHY — asking it to redo the math catches most mistakes. Then check one line yourself with a calculator. Thirty seconds.

3 Add real life

> Now add: **[X]**% waste on spirits, a realistic juice yield (how much juice I actually get from a case of limes), and the garnish cost. What's the true cost per serve now?

WHY — paper cost and real cost differ by 10–20%. That gap is where profit quietly leaks. →

4

See your price options

> Show me the menu price at 18%, 20%, and 22% pour cost, rounded to prices that look right on a menu. For each price, show my profit in dollars per drink — not just the percentage. My current menu runs **[YOUR PRICE RANGE]**. Which price fits?

WHY — percentages flatter cheap drinks. Dollars per drink is what pays rent. Look at both before choosing.

5

Know where the flex is

> If I ever had to make this drink 8% cheaper without guests noticing, what would you change first — and what would you refuse to change? Rank the options by how easy they'd be to taste.

WHY — you may never use it, but knowing where the recipe can bend makes you sharp in any menu meeting.

THE BAR — BEFORE THE PRICE GOES ON THE MENU

— **You checked one line of math by hand.** If that line is wrong, it's all wrong.

— **Prices came from this month's invoices** — supplier prices creep.

— **The true cost includes waste, juice yield, and garnish** — not just liquor.

— **The final numbers live in your spreadsheet**, not just in the chat.

— You know your profit in dollars, not only in percent.

03 Batch it for volume

THE JOB Scale one recipe up for a busy night, a tap, a freezer, or an event — without wrecking the drink or wasting product.

TOOL PICK

Your main chat AI. Same math rule as Build 02: make it show every calculation. For events, pair this with the event order-sheet prompt in the quick reference.

LOAD YOUR BAR

You need: the recipe, how many serves you want (or what volume), your bottle or container sizes, how it will be served (shaken to order? from the freezer? on tap?), and how much fridge space you honestly have.

1 Sort what can be batched from what can't

I'm batching this recipe: **[SPEC]**. First, sort every ingredient into two lists: "fine to batch ahead" and "must be added fresh per drink" (citrus juice, dairy, egg, anything fizzy). For the fresh list, tell me exactly how much to add per serve at service.

WHY — the classic batching mistake is batching the lime juice. Sort first, math second.

2 Scale it up

Scale the batchable part to **[NUMBER OF SERVES or TOTAL VOLUME]**. Give me the batch recipe in liters and oz, then split it into **[YOUR BOTTLE SIZE]** bottles. Show the multiplication line by line.

WHY — one wrong scale factor ruins a $200 batch. Line-by-line math, then check one line yourself.

3 Decide the water on purpose

This batch will be served **[STIRRED TO ORDER / FROM A −18°C FREEZER / ON TAP / OVER ICE]**. Should I add water to the batch, and exactly how much? Explain why for my serving style. If it's going in a freezer, check the alcohol level is high enough that it won't freeze solid.

WHY — dilution is a decision, not an accident. Freezer bottles that won't pour and tap drinks that taste hot both come from skipping this step. →

4 Write the label

> Write a bottle label for this batch: what's inside, date made, use-by date, storage temperature, and the per-serve instruction (for example: "2.5 oz batch + 0.75 oz fresh lime, shake"). Then tell me a realistic shelf life, and what it will look or smell like when it's gone off.

WHY — an unlabeled bottle gets mis-poured at 11pm. The use-by date protects your guest and your name.

5 Check the plan against reality

> Reality check: will **[N]** serves fit in my fridge space — **[DESCRIBE IT]**? And if the night runs 20% busier than planned, what's my backup: batch extra loose, or build the overflow from the well?

WHY — ninety seconds of "what if" now saves you doing math in your head mid-rush.

THE BAR — BEFORE YOU SCALE IT

— **You tasted one serve made from the batch** next to one made fresh. They should match.

— **Nothing perishable is in the bottle** — fresh goes in per drink, at service.

— **The water was decided on purpose**, and freezer batches were checked so they still pour.

— **Every bottle has a label**: date, use-by, per-serve instruction.

— The math was checked twice — once by the AI, once by you.

04 Fix a drink that's off

THE JOB A drink is close but wrong. Find out why, fix it with the smallest change that works, and write the fix down.

TOOL PICK

Your main chat AI. If it takes photos, send one — a picture can reveal problems you didn't mention: separation, dead foam, wrong ice.

LOAD YOUR BAR

You need: the recipe **as it was actually made** (ask whoever made it — it's often not what's written), your ice and shake/stir times, and the clearest description of the problem you can manage.

1 Describe it properly, ask for causes only

> You are a cocktail development consultant. This drink is off. Recipe as actually made: **[SPEC + METHOD + ICE + SHAKE/STIR TIME]**. What I taste, in order: first sip **[X]**, middle **[Y]**, finish **[Z]**. What I want instead: **[TARGET]**. Don't fix it yet. First give me the three most likely causes, ranked, with one line of reasoning each.

WHY — "diagnose before you fix" stops the AI grabbing a generic answer. First sip / middle / finish gives it real information.

2 Try the smallest fix first

> Take the most likely cause. Give me the single smallest change that would fix it — a ratio tweak, a technique change, a temperature — with the exact new spec. Save the bigger rewrites for later.

WHY — change one thing at a time. Change three and you'll never know which one worked.

3 Make it, taste it, report back

> Made it. Result: **[BETTER / WORSE / DIFFERENT — describe what changed]**. What do we try next?

WHY — you're running taste tests with the AI as your lab partner. Two or three rounds usually lands it. Same chat throughout. →

4 If small fixes aren't working, change the structure

> Small changes aren't landing. Keep the idea of the drink, but rebuild it in a different format — sour instead of stirred, split the base spirit, different lengthener. Give me two options with full specs, and one line on what each version gives up.

WHY — sometimes the drink is fighting its own format. Changing the structure is allowed — as a decision, not out of frustration.

5 Lock it in and write it down

> Fixed. Final spec: **[SPEC]**. Write a short note for my recipe book: what was wrong, what fixed it, and the general lesson. Then update the build instructions so a trainee gets it right first time.

WHY — writing down the lesson is how fixing one drink makes you better at every drink.

THE BAR — BEFORE YOU CALL IT FIXED

— **It's fixed at service speed** — real ice, real glassware, made fast. Not just at the bench.

— **You changed one thing per round** and wrote down each result.

— **Someone else tasted it** without knowing what changed — and agreed.

— **The spec sheet and training notes were updated the same day** — or the old version comes back.

— You can say what was wrong in one sentence. If you can't, it's not diagnosed.

05 Master new kit or technique

THE JOB New equipment (iSi whipper, sous-vide, carbonation rig) or a new technique (clarification, fat-washing) — go from opening the box to a routine your whole team can run.

TOOL PICK

Three tools, in order: Perplexity finds how the pros do it, with sources. A YouTube video's transcript gives you their exact method. Your main chat AI turns it all into your house version. Photos of the kit and any failed batch help too.

LOAD YOUR BAR

You need: the equipment (brand and model) or the technique, the first thing you want to make with it, how much prep time you have, and your team's level.

1 Get the short version of the science — in your chat AI

> Explain **[TECHNIQUE or EQUIPMENT]** to a working bartender. First: how it works, in two sentences. Then: the 5 most useful things I could make with it in a cocktail bar, ranked by wow-factor for the effort.

WHY — knowing *why* it works is what lets you fix it when it doesn't. Two sentences is enough.

2 Find how the pros do it — in Perplexity

> How do professional cocktail bars do **[TECHNIQUE]**? Compare the main methods, tell me which is most reliable for a small bar without lab equipment, and give me your sources — including the one video or written guide professionals recommend most.

WHY — Perplexity searches the web and shows its sources. You leave this step with the best video for the next step.

3 Break the video down using its transcript

Open the video on YouTube. Tap the description, then **"Show transcript."** Select all the transcript text and copy it. (On a computer: the "…more" line under the video → Show transcript.) Now paste it into your chat AI with the prompt below.

> Here's the transcript of a video about **[TECHNIQUE]**: **[PASTE TRANSCRIPT]**. Pull out the exact method: every step, amount, time, and temperature mentioned. List anything the video does differently from what you told me earlier — and tell me which way is safer for a small bar, and why.

WHY — the transcript turns a 20-minute video into an exact written recipe you can question, save, and turn into your own method. This trick works on any how-to video. →

4 Get your test-batch method — failures included

> Combine everything we have into one method for a small test batch: amounts, times, temperatures, food-safety notes at each step, and how long the result keeps. Then list the 5 most common ways this goes wrong, what each looks like while it's happening, and whether I rescue it or bin it. I have a **[YOUR PREP WINDOW]** window.

WHY — always test small, and read the failures before you start. Every mistake becomes a checklist item instead of a mystery.

5 Report your test results

> Test batch done. Results: **[WHAT HAPPENED — texture, clarity, yield, taste; add photos if your app takes them]**. What went wrong, what do I adjust, and what should I watch for on round two?

WHY — same loop as fixing a drink: test, report, adjust. Two or three rounds and the technique is yours.

6 Turn it into a one-page house guide

> It works. Write a one-page guide for my bar: the method with our exact amounts and settings, safety notes, cleaning steps, storage and labeling, and a small table of problems → causes → fixes. Write it for a trainee who has never seen this before.

WHY — a technique only you can run is a bottleneck. The one-pager makes it the bar's skill, not just yours.

THE BAR — BEFORE IT TOUCHES THE MENU

— **You've run it start to finish three times** — at least once without looking at notes.

— **Safety was checked against the manufacturer's manual.** The AI adds to the manual; it never replaces it.

— **Every output is labeled** with date, use-by, and storage — same rule as batching.

— **One other person learned it from your one-pager alone.** That's the real test of the guide.

— You know what a failed batch costs, and it's built into the prep plan.

06 Make it look like it tastes

THE JOB Turn one new drink into menu artwork and a week of social posts — without hiring a photographer.

TOOL PICK

Two steps, two tools. First your chat AI writes the image prompt (steps 1–2). Then an image tool makes the picture: **Midjourney** (best look), **ChatGPT or Gemini** (image making built into the chat you already use), **Firefly** (safest for print). **Video:** your phone + a chat-AI shot list; Kling, Runway, or Veo for mood clips only.

LOAD YOUR BAR

You need: the drink (recipe + its story), your look (brand colors, the vibe, links or screenshots of 2 posts you're proud of), and where this is going: menu, print, Instagram, TikTok.

1 Decide the look before making any images

> You are an art director for a **[YOUR VIBE]** bar. For **[DRINK + STORY]**, going on **[MENU / INSTAGRAM / A POSTER]**: describe 3 different visual directions. For each: the mood, the lighting, the surface the drink sits on, the colors, and how the shot is framed. No images yet.

WHY — making images before choosing a direction gets you pretty pictures of the wrong idea. Choose first.

2 Have the AI write your image prompt

> I choose direction **[NUMBER]**. Now write the exact prompt I'll paste into an image tool. Describe: the drink and glass, the surface, the lighting (what kind, from which side), the camera angle and lens feel (close-up or wide, sharp or soft background), the mood and colors, and the format — **[SQUARE FOR MENU / VERTICAL 9:16 FOR STORIES]**. End it with: no hands, no text, no brand labels. One paragraph.

WHY — camera and lighting words are what image tools respond to, and your chat AI knows them better than you do. Let it write the prompt; you just approve it.

3 Make the images — several

> Paste that prompt into **Midjourney, ChatGPT, Gemini, or Firefly**. Make at least 4 versions — same prompt, several tries. Save the two best. You're choosing, not committing. →

4 Improve the best one — one change at a time

> Keep this image's framing exactly as it is. Change only one thing: **[e.g. "the garnish to a dried orange wheel" / "the lighting to feel later at night"]**.

WHY — same rule as fixing a drink: one change at a time. Improving a winner beats starting over.

5 Get a shot list for the real drink

> Back in your chat AI: Write me a phone shot list to film this drink for real in 20 minutes before service: 6 shots, with the exact angle for each, where the light should come from, and the one slow-motion moment worth three takes.

WHY — the AI image is the concept. Real footage of the real pour is what guests trust. Use both, honestly.

6 Turn one drink into a week of posts

> Make a 7-day posting plan for **[INSTAGRAM / TIKTOK]** from this one drink. For each day: the format (reel, photo, or story), an opening line that stops scrolling, a 60-word caption in my voice (samples above), hashtags, and which image or clip to use. Include one post that teaches something and one that tells the drink's story.

WHY — the plan stops you posting the same glamour shot five different ways.

THE BAR — BEFORE YOU POST

— **No AI image is ever shown as a photo of the drink you serve.** Concepts and artwork only — labeled if guests could be confused.

— **The real drink appears in real footage** at least as often as AI art.

— **Read one caption out loud.** If you wouldn't say it at the bar, rewrite it.

— No brand labels or recognizable faces in AI images.

— Each post has one job — bring guests in, teach, or tell the story. Not all three.

07 Allergen-proof the menu

THE JOB New menu launches Friday. Everyone on the floor needs the allergen answer, the substitution, and the exact sentence to say — before doors open.

TOOL PICK

Your main chat AI builds the chart and the scripts. Afterward, load the checked chart into **NotebookLM** so staff can ask it questions — it only answers from your document, which is exactly what you want here.

LOAD YOUR BAR

You need: full recipes **including what's inside your house preps** — the orgeat, the fat-wash, the foam. Allergens hide in preps. If you know your local allergen rules, add those too.

1 Build the chart — marked as a draft

> Build an allergen and dietary chart for this menu: **[ALL SPECS, INCLUDING PREP RECIPES]**. Check each drink for: egg, dairy, nuts, gluten, honey (not vegan), sulfites. Title the chart "DRAFT — NOT CHECKED AGAINST LABELS YET." Where the recipe doesn't tell you enough, write "unknown — check the label." Never guess.

WHY — "never guess" must be written in the prompt. A confident wrong answer about nuts is the most dangerous sentence in this book.

2 Make it confess what it's not sure about

> Go back through the chart. List every entry you are less than fully sure about, and why. Check these known traps: orgeat (nuts), Worcestershire (fish), some bitters (gluten), honey syrup (not vegan), egg in foams and washes.

WHY — this pass shows you exactly which entries a human must check. It always finds something. →

3 Check the labels yourself — no AI in this step

There is no prompt for this step. It's you, the physical bottles, and every product label — including the ingredients of your own preps. Correct the chart. Only remove the word DRAFT when every entry is confirmed. About twenty minutes, and the AI cannot do it for you.

WHY — this step is the whole card. Everything before it saves time. Nothing before it counts as checking.

4 Add substitutions that actually hold up

The chart is now checked — updated version pasted below. For each flagged drink, give me either a substitution that keeps the drink's character, or an honest "can't be modified — offer **[ANOTHER DRINK ON MY LIST]** instead." Note when a substitution changes the texture, and how.

WHY — a bad substitution is worse than a graceful "let me steer you to this instead." Always ask for the steer option.

5 Write the exact sentences for the floor

Now the service part: for each flagged drink, write the one-line answer a bartender says to the guest, and the follow-up line if the guest says "severe allergy" — which must always include telling the manager and remaking with clean tins. Format: one small card per drink, printable.

WHY — the chart protects the guest on paper. The sentence protects them at 10pm on a Friday. You need both.

THE BAR — NO EXCEPTIONS

- **Every entry was checked against a real label by a human** before the word DRAFT came off. Menu change or new supplier? The word DRAFT goes back on.
- **"Severe allergy" always goes to the manager** — clean tins, remake, no exceptions, however busy.
- **Every house prep bottle lists its own ingredients**, with a date.
- The checked chart lives where the team can reach it mid-service — not in the office.

08 Teach the team the new menu

THE JOB Ten new recipes into eight heads in one week — so launch night runs like week six.

TOOL PICK

Your main chat AI builds the materials. **NotebookLM** is the team's study tool: load the menu and training doc, and they can quiz it on the train — it can even make an audio briefing from your documents.

LOAD YOUR BAR

You need: the new menu (recipes + the story behind each drink), your team list with levels (two seniors, three mid-level, one new barback…), and how much training time you honestly have.

1 Make a one-page card per drink

> For each drink on this menu, make a one-page training card: the spec, the build order, glass/ice/garnish, a 15-second story to tell guests, the questions guests will likely ask, and the single most likely mistake on a busy night. Printable, one page each.

WHY — "the most likely mistake" line is what makes it a training card instead of just a spec sheet. It points attention where it'll be needed.

2 Spread it over the week

> Build a 5-day learning plan for my team — **[LIST + LEVELS]** — using **[X]** minutes of pre-shift each day: which drinks on which day, who leads each session, and homework that takes under 15 minutes. The seniors and the new barback should not get the same plan — show the difference.

WHY — two drinks a day for five days beats one long menu meeting. Spacing is how memory works.

3 Turn the drilling into a game

> Turn the menu into a 15-minute pre-shift game: 10 spec questions, 5 guest situations (an allergy, "something not too sweet," a guest in a hurry), 5 build-order challenges. Include the answer key and a simple way to keep score across the week.

WHY — a game gets played; a quiz gets endured. The week-long scoreboard is what makes it stick. →

4 Practice the hard conversations

> Now play a guest at my bar. Rotate through: someone who can't decide ("surprise me"), someone doubtful about the **[UNUSUAL DRINK]**, someone allergic to **[X]**, and someone in a hurry. I'll answer as if I'm on shift. After each one, step out of character and tell me what to say better. Save the best answers so I can share them with the team.

WHY — bartenders drill recipes but never drill sentences. Use voice mode and this feels like the real thing.

5 Adjust after the first weekend

> Launch weekend is done. What went wrong: **[YOUR NOTES — slow builds, missed recommendations, confusion on drink X]**. Update the training cards to target exactly these problems, and plan next week's two pre-shifts around them.

WHY — training that ignores what actually happened is a ritual, not a system.

THE BAR — HOW YOU KNOW IT WORKED

— **By day five, anyone can build any drink** without the cheat sheet.

— **Every server tells each drink's story in their own words** — one natural sentence.

— **Allergy answers are instant** and match the checked chart from Build 07.

— Launch-night ticket times are close to a normal night's.

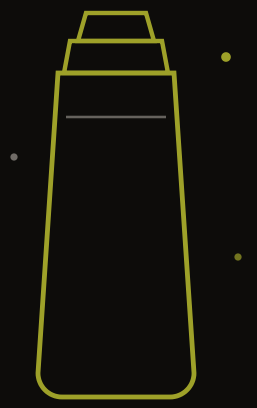
— The new barback taught someone something by Friday.

PART TWO

The Quick Reference

More prompts, ready to copy. Each one works on its own — and works better if you treat it like a build: read the answer, then push back. Ask for the math. Ask what it's unsure about. Say what's wrong with the draft.

RESEARCH · CREATION · ADMIN · MENU & MARKETING · TRAINING & CAREER



RESEARCH

R1 Flavor pairing map

TOOL · ANY CHAT AI

You are a flavor scientist and veteran bartender. Map the flavor of **[INGREDIENT]** for me: (1) its main flavor notes in plain words, (2) 10 classic pairings, (3) 5 surprising pairings that work, with one line on why, (4) 3 pairings to avoid, (5) which spirits carry it best. Short, scannable list.

R2 Take apart a classic

TOOL · ANY CHAT AI

You are a cocktail educator. Break the **[CLASSIC]** into its working parts: core spirit, sour/bitter balance, sweetness, dilution, aroma. For each part, give 3 swaps — from safe to bold — that keep the drink balanced. Flag any swap that changes how I need to make the drink.

R3 History without the myths

TOOL · CHAT AI — WEB SEARCH ON FOR DATES

Give me the accurate history of **[COCKTAIL or CATEGORY]**: where and when it started, how the recipe changed, and the popular myths versus what the evidence says. Then a 30-second version I can tell a guest while I build their drink.

R4 Know a bottle fast

TOOL · PERPLEXITY, OR CHAT AI WITH WEB SEARCH

Brief me on **[SPIRIT / PRODUCER / BOTTLING]**: how it's made, where, what makes it different from its nearest rivals, and how bartenders use it. End with three talking points: one for a curious beginner, one for an enthusiast, one for an industry guest. Keep the whole thing under 300 words.

R5 Ingredient safety check

TOOL · ANY CHAT AI — THEN VERIFY THE SOURCE IT NAMES

Explain **[INGREDIENT or PROCESS — egg white, aquafaba, activated charcoal, tonka bean]** in drinks: what it actually does, any health or legal issues (say if rules differ by country), safe amounts, and how to handle it. Tell me what kind of official source I should double-check this against — do not let me rely on you alone.

R6 Trend scan — turn web search on

TOOL · PERPLEXITY, OR CHAT AI WITH WEB SEARCH

Search the web for current cocktail trends that matter to a **[VENUE TYPE]** in **[CITY]**: techniques, ingredients, drink formats, service styles. Mark each one rising, peaking, or fading. Suggest one cheap, low-risk way to test each on my menu. Tell me honestly which trends are hype.

CREATION

C1 Riff on a classic

TOOL · CHATGPT OR CLAUDE

You are a cocktail developer. Give me 5 original variations on the **[CLASSIC]**, each built around **[INGREDIENT / FLAVOR / HOUSE PRODUCT]**. For each: a name, the full spec in oz and ml, what changed and why it still balances, and how hard it is to make on a busy night. Rank them by which would sell best at a **[VENUE TYPE]**.

C2 Zero-proof with backbone

TOOL · CHATGPT OR CLAUDE

Design **[N]** non-alcoholic cocktails for a **[VENUE TYPE]** with real complexity — bitterness, texture, length — not juice with a garnish. I have: **[NA SPIRITS / INGREDIENTS]**. For each: full spec, method, rough cost level, and which classic it nods to, so my team can talk about it with confidence.

C3 Use it before you lose it

TOOL · ANY CHAT AI

I have **[SURPLUS INGREDIENT + AMOUNT + CONDITION]** to use within **[TIME]**. Give me: (1) a syrup or prep that extends its life, with method and how long it keeps, (2) one cocktail using that prep, full spec, (3) a bigger batch if it's worth running as a special.

C4 Describe a taste, get a recipe

TOOL · CHATGPT OR CLAUDE

I want a drink that tastes like **[DESCRIBE THE FEELING — "salted mango with smoke" / "a bakery in winter"]**. Give me 3 possible specs on different base spirits. For each, explain which ingredient creates which part of the taste. Include one cheap version and one showpiece version.

C5 Menu & poster art — for your image tool

TOOL · MIDJOURNEY, GEMINI, OR FIREFLY

[ART STYLE — art deco / vintage travel poster / Japanese woodblock] illustration for a cocktail bar event: **[THE SCENE]**, colors: **[YOUR BRAND COLORS]**, strong composition, empty space at the top for a title, no text anywhere in the image, sharp enough to print.

C6 Mood video — for Kling, Runway, or Veo

TOOL · KLING, RUNWAY, OR VEO

30-second vertical (9:16) cinematic clip: **[KEY MOMENTS — "clear ice dropping into a rocks glass, slow-motion amber pour, citrus oils spraying"]**. Warm low bar light, shallow focus, slow motion on the pour, no faces, no brand labels.

ADMIN

A1 Audit the whole menu's profit

TOOL · ANY CHAT AI — KEEP THE MASTER IN A SPREADSHEET

> You are a beverage director. Here's my menu with each drink's cost per serve and menu price: **[PASTE LIST]**. Show: pour cost % per drink, overall margin using sales mix **[PASTE MIX, or say "assume equal sales"]**, which drinks to re-price, re-work, or cut, and where a small price rise is safe. Give me the three changes worth the most money first, with the math shown.

A2 Event order sheet

TOOL · ANY CHAT AI

> Build my order and prep sheet for an event: **[GUESTS]** guests, **[HOURS]** hours, menu: **[DRINKS]**, drinking pace: **[DRINKS PER GUEST PER HOUR, or say "use the standard for this type of event"]**. Calculate: bottles per product with a 15% safety buffer, ice in kg, garnish and juice amounts, batch volumes, and glassware counts. Format it as a checklist I can hand to my team.

A3 Build a count sheet

TOOL · ANY CHAT AI — PASTE RESULT INTO A SPREADSHEET

> Make me a bar inventory count sheet for about **[N]** products, organized by station and category (spirits by type, beer, wine, non-alc, preps). Columns: product, bottle size, full bottles, tenths for open bottles, par, reorder point, supplier. Output as a table I can paste into a spreadsheet. Then give me a 5-step weekly counting routine two people can finish in an hour.

A4 Find where stock is leaking

TOOL · ANY CHAT AI

> You are a beverage cost controller. My numbers this period — what we should have used vs what we actually used: **[PASTE BY CATEGORY OR PRODUCT]**. Rank the likely causes (over-pouring, spills, unrecorded comps, transfers, theft, counting errors) by how well each fits this pattern. For each: what evidence would confirm it. Then a two-week plan to close the gap without accusing anyone unfairly.

A5 Set order levels

TOOL · ANY CHAT AI

> Help me set par levels (how much to keep in stock). Weekly sales: **[DATA]**. Deliveries arrive: **[DAYS]**. Storage limits: **[NOTES]**. For each product: recommended par and reorder point, with one line of reasoning. Flag dead stock to sell down, and slow movers to cut at the next menu change.

A6 Build the prep schedule

TOOL · ANY CHAT AI

> Build a prep schedule for this menu: **[MENU + HOUSE PREPS AND HOW LONG EACH KEEPS]**. We do about **[N]** covers a day. Sort preps into daily, every-2–3-days, and weekly. Give batch sizes, time estimates, and a printable morning checklist ordered so the slowest jobs start first.

MENU & MARKETING

M1 Menu lines that sell

TOOL · CHATGPT OR CLAUDE

Write menu descriptions for these drinks: **[SPECS + THE STORY BEHIND EACH]**. Rules: 15 words maximum, lead with the most tempting element, no clichés like "hand-crafted" or "perfectly balanced," and match the style of these two examples I like: **[PASTE 2]**. Give two options per drink — one about the taste, one about the story.

M2 Name the drink

TOOL · ANY CHAT AI

Name this cocktail: **[SPEC + THE IDEA BEHIND IT + MY BAR'S VIBE]**. Give me 10 names across four styles: atmospheric, witty, nodding to a classic, and local/story-based. No puns we'll regret in a year. Flag any name that already belongs to a known cocktail or sounds like a trademark I should check.

M3 Promote an event

TOOL · ANY CHAT AI

Promote this event: **[WHAT + DATE + VENUE + TICKETS OR WALK-IN + WHY IT'S SPECIAL]**. Write: an Instagram caption, a 50-word listing blurb, a 100-word email invite to partners, a short paragraph briefing my staff so they can sell it in conversation, and 3 story/reel ideas for the week before.

M4 Answer a review

TOOL · CHATGPT OR CLAUDE

Reply to this review: **"[PASTE IT]"**. What actually happened, if relevant: **[CONTEXT]**. Rules: thank them sincerely, answer their specific points, never argue in public, and if it's negative, invite them to continue privately. Under 80 words, in the voice of **[NAME]** at **[VENUE]**.

M5 A week of posts from one drink

TOOL · ANY CHAT AI

My new cocktail: **[NAME + SPEC + STORY]**. Build a 7-day Instagram/TikTok plan. Per day: format (reel, photo, story), an opening line that stops scrolling, a 60-word caption in my voice — sample: **[PASTE ONE]** — hashtags, and what I need to film. Include one post that teaches and one that tells the story.

TRAINING & CAREER

T1 Menu quiz for the team

TOOL · CHAT AI — THEN LOAD INTO NOTEBOOKLM

Turn this menu into a training quiz: **[SPECS]**. 10 recipe-recall questions, 5 guest situations (an allergy, a substitution, a recommendation), 5 build-order questions. Include the answer key, and a way to run it as a 15-minute pre-shift game with scores.

T2 Barback to bartender

TOOL · CHATGPT OR CLAUDE

Design an 8-week plan to train a strong barback into a service bartender at a **[VENUE TYPE]**. Week by week: the theme, the specific skills with a clear pass/fail test for each, homework under 15 minutes (tasting, reading, practice), and a final assessment. Assume 3 hours of dedicated training a week plus practice on shift.

T3 Competition coach

TOOL · CHATGPT OR CLAUDE

I'm entering **[COMPETITION]** with this drink: **[SPEC + CONCEPT]**. Act as my coach: compare my concept honestly against what usually wins, tighten my 3-minute presentation (draft: **[PASTE, or say "help me write one"]**), predict the 5 questions judges will ask and give me strong answers, and build a 2-week practice schedule ending in a full run-through.

T4 Train your palate vocabulary

TOOL · CHAT AI — VOICE MODE

Play a tasting game with me. Pick **[SPIRIT CATEGORY]**. Describe a real bottle's taste without naming it; I guess the style, region, or age. Then swap: I name a bottle, describe it, and you correct my tasting note and teach me two sharper words. Keep score over 10 rounds.

T5 Fix your CV & bio

TOOL · CHATGPT OR CLAUDE

Rewrite my hospitality CV (or bio) for **[THE TARGET — a head bartender job / a brand ambassador application / a guest shift]**. My experience, roughly: **[LIST IT]**. Lead with results and numbers (sales, launches, competitions), cut job-description language, keep it to **[LENGTH]**, and match the tone of **[WHERE I'M APPLYING]**.

T6 Troubleshoot equipment mid-shift

TOOL · CHAT AI — ADD A PHOTO IF YOU CAN

My **[EQUIPMENT]** is doing this: **[DESCRIBE — sounds, error lights, behavior]**. It's a **[BRAND/MODEL/AGE if known]**. Walk me through diagnosis starting from the most likely and cheapest cause. Tell me clearly: what's safe to check right now mid-service, what waits until close, and at what point I stop and call a technician.

The fine print

Taste everything. The AI has never tasted anything. Its recipes are starting points. The glass decides.

Check every number against your invoices and till. Make the AI show its math, then check one line yourself.

Allergen answers are drafts until a human checks every one against real product labels. Every menu change resets this.

Check local law on anything about serving alcohol, health claims, or unusual ingredients.

Label AI images when guests might think they're photos of the real drink.

Watch what you paste. Recipes and menus: fine. Sales data and staff matters: keep out of free tools.

This book teaches a way of working — not a shortcut around the craft. The bartenders who get the most from AI are the ones with the best palates and the clearest standards. It sharpens judgment. It doesn't replace it.

DRINKS BY NEAT

Pour something *good.*

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